

For a Better World

SHASHWAT RAUT, 21,
MUMBAI

Arts graduate, St Xavier's College, **Mumbai**

India is a country of abundance—of cultures, languages and love. I grew up in an India that exudes brilliance, that excuses mistakes and that exercises pride in humility. But growing up I realised, 'your India' and 'my India' are different. There is a different India whose importance transcends that of my privileged India. There is an India full of pain, that doesn't let you be you, where your worth is realised every five years. It is an India of hardship. And then there is an idea of a new India where bigotry rules over humanity, where majoritarianism is pampered and the marginalised are further isolated.

At the same time, there's an India of hope where communities are stronger than predatory leaders. There is an India built on ties that go beyond caste, creed or religion, a nation that has an unflinching spirit and tenacity. This is the India we'll proudly call truly incredible. ■

"There is an India full of pain, but there's also an India of hope, built on ties that go beyond caste or creed"